

PROJECT STATEMENT

This project examines the datafication of everyday commuting through a speculative “smart mobility optimisation” system that captures, measures, and restructures how movement is understood within urban space. In this near-future scenario, public transport, pedestrian pathways, and shared environments are embedded with sensors that quantify actions such as walking speed, waiting time, route choice, and behavioral efficiency. While these systems are framed as tools for improving sustainability and convenience, they also reduce complex, lived experiences into simplified, measurable units.

The work is grounded in a self-generated dataset documenting my own commuting routines over several days. Using a structured yet subjective observation process, I recorded actions including walking, pausing, transferring, and navigating crowded conditions. This dataset is deliberately interpretive, foregrounding the role of human judgment in defining what counts as data and how it is structured.

The resulting visualisation takes the form of an interactive interface composed of two contrasting layers. The first layer consists of hand-drawn data visualisations that express rhythm, interruption, and embodied experience through irregular, fluid marks. The second layer is a speculative dashboard that translates the same data into standardized metrics, such as efficiency scores and optimization pathways, and presents them through a clean, authoritative interface. Through interaction, users can shift between these perspectives or witness the gradual disappearance of the hand-drawn layer as the system’s logic asserts dominance. By juxtaposing and transforming these representations, the project reveals how institutional data systems flatten nuance, prioritise optimisation, and obscure the interpretive processes behind data production. Engaging with ideas of data sovereignty, it questions who controls data and what forms of knowledge are lost when lived experience is reduced to measurable outputs. Ultimately, the work advocates for the value of ambiguity, context, and human interpretation in understanding how we move through the city.